

Decision trail: Coding, Codebook, & Meeting notes

Stage 1

ROUND 1 —in vivo coding

- Single coder: lead researcher
- Balanced 20% of the dataset, coding a total of 384 participants out of the 1,788.

1788 total in full dataset → [20%] (357.6) 358

UK

237, 18-30 → [20%] (47.4) 47/48

231, 31-54 → [20%] (46.2) 46

223, 46-60 → [20%] (44.6) 45

220, 61-75 → [20%] 44

US

234, 18-30 → [20%] (46.8) 47

227, 31-54 → [20%] (45.4) 45/46

217, 46-60 → [20%] (43.4) 43/44

199, 61-75 → [20%] (39.8) 40

—12 stimuli groups—

= for each stimuli group:

4 UK18-30

4 UK31-45

4 UK46-60

4 UK61-75

4 US18-30

4 US31-45

4 US46-60

4 US61-75 <<<made equal, instead of rounding down to 3

Total ptps to be coded in initial 20% → N=384

- Group similar codes together into categories making a preliminary categorised codebook, retaining all in vivo codes.

ROUND 2 —second coding pass, iterating on the preliminary categories

- new category “scene qualities and atmosphere”

- (for initial coding): move any temporal & narrative positioning codes (e.g. opening scene, climatic, ending scene, transition) to *Turning points and Narrative moments*

See Stage 1 Codebook for initial categorised codes at this point.

The iterated categories were reduced and organised with definitions in preparation for the research assistant coders. In vivo codes were removed to see if the categories were functional and parseable by the coders.

Stage 2

From the refined codebook 26.08.25, these were my initial emergent thematic analysis ideas:

- **THEME 1: Narrational**
 - Place, Settings, & Scenes
 - People & Characters
 - Actions & Movements
 - Objects & Things
- **THEME 2: Referential**
 - Music & Sounds
 - Media, Art, & Technology
 - Chronology & Events
- **THEME 1: Experiential/Evaluational?**
 - Personal significance & Subjective experiences
 - Symbolic & Sensory representations

20% data subsets for RAs

1,788 participants, but using the number of thought descriptions to split the data.

→ count of 14,115 thought descriptions

20% of 14,115 = 2823 exactly

3rd coding pass for self → code 20% of each 20% RA subset

565 participants from each —page 3, 7, 9, 14, 21, 25

= [IDs: 201-300; 601-700; 801-900; 1301-1400; 2001-2100; 2401-2465]

- **Notes for self (after coding pass 3)**

→ codes/categories to go back over:

- Check geographical code (I coded some -ish [e.g. British] descriptors there that shouldn't be)

- Check demographics code (might need to move a load of geographical coded sections here —also think I’ve also put some media genre stuff here that needs moving...)
- Merge action modifiers “Emotion Tone” with “Style, Manner [...]” —no real or important difference necessary for this purpose
- merge animal/creature with their descriptors (not necessary i.m.o.)
- Check through video game mentions of “playing” to put in “[...] Leisure Activities”<?
- Check speed (things I’ve coded here are not all necessarily speed...?)
- Check social and relational acts (take out those “chasing” ones etc.)
- Check media brands, companies, devices (I have put things like “phone” and “TV” there... check your coding)
- Look for “boss” music to put in “music and sound in media”, “packaging”, “roles [...]”
- ^ Also “level” to put in “media packaging”
- Should aliens go in “mythical” people, “creatures”, “roles” ..?
- Review “text” category? Is this working? Is it necessary? Would it be better suited elsewhere?

Remove participant ID 824 for extensive task-irrelevant opinionated commentary on current events (political, societal), using open-textbox as a place to rant (multiple times appears frustrated at time-limit on response boxes to then continue with rant from previous trial).

Remove participant ID 1764 for obscure mention of an “AI’s assessment” —unclear whether talking about using one themselves for this study, so removed for clarity.

= participant *N* down from 1,788 to 1,786

Some participant-reported thought trials (*N*=14,115) gave invalid free-response variants of “NA” (e.g. na, N/A, etc.) ← found through MAXQDA search (better than NVivo)

= thought *N* down to 14,099

Notes from RA meetings

★ Use codeable categories with lowest percentage agreements to guide RA discussions

- Anything < 95%

Codeable-categories with overall agreement percentage across all coders:

Ordered lowest to highest percentage agreement

Codes	% agreement
[Places, Settings, & Scenes]	63.23
[Actions & Movements]	64.14

[Music & Sounds]	72.12
[People & Characters]	72.96
[Media, Art, & Technology]	73.30
[Chronology & Events]	77.50
[Character Descriptors]	77.92
Human-made and Societal PI...	80.54
Media Genres, Eras, and For...	81.31
[Personal Significance & Subi...	82.68
Musical and Sonic Qualities	84.46
[Natural World]	86.05
[Objects & Things]	88.17
[Symbolic & Sensory Represe...	88.37
Genre, Cultural, and Aestheti...	89.25
Scene Qualities and Atmosph...	90.22
[Sensory Details]	90.81
Directed Movement and Travel	91.04
Emotions and Affective States	91.09
Events and Occasions	91.25
Named Media and Art Refere...	91.25
Historical and Cultural Periods	91.36
Instruments, Ensembles, and...	91.58
[Visual Details]	91.91
Dancing and Music-linked Mo...	92.53
Creating and Performing	93.99

[Social Presence and Configu...	94.00
Professions and Pursuits	94.17
Evaluative Opinions and Prefe...	94.44
Resting, Idling, and Leisure A...	94.59
Time of Day and Seasonality	94.68
Named Regional and Geogra...	95.05
Landforms and Terrain	95.18
Vehicles and Transport	95.22
[Action Modifiers]	95.40
Personal Time-linked Connec...	95.43
Relationships and Kinship Ties	95.50
Named Artists and Musicians	95.53
Attentional and Perceptual Ac...	95.54
Demographics and Identity	95.55
Social Groups and Collectives	95.73
Music and Sound in Media	95.84
[Outfit Details]	95.85
Light and Illumination	95.97
Public and Domestic Everyda...	96.06
Music-related Professions	96.43
Water and Aquatic Features	96.48
Colour	96.51
Media Packaging of Story Str...	96.76
Sky and Space	96.78

Technical and Structural Notes	96.86
Music Use and Function	96.86
Traits, Affective States, and A...	96.88
Weather and Climate	96.90
[Named Figures]	96.91
Conceptual and Metaphorical...	97.11
Animals and Creatures	97.31
Roles, Archetypes, and Tropes	97.50
Plants and Vegetation	97.55
With Groups of People	97.55
Outfit Descriptor	97.63
Consumables	97.68
Personal Significance	97.79
Media Companies, Brands, an...	97.82
Dyadic, With One Other	97.85
Conflict, Harm, and Wrongdoi...	97.91
Spatial Position and Orientati...	97.94
Object Features and Qualities	98.05
Narrative Progression and Tu...	98.15
Preparing, Waiting, Anticipati...	98.26
Style, Manner, and Characteri...	98.26
speed	98.33
Daily life, Working, and Effort...	98.36
Non-directional Motions and...	98.38

Transforming, Learning, and...	98.43
Eating, Drinking, Substance...	98.46
Alone, Self-focused	98.46
Social and Relational Acts	98.47
Songs and Lyrics	98.56
Emotional Tone	98.56
Hair	98.57
Fictional, Futuristic, and Fant...	98.59
Playback and Listening Devic...	98.79
Exercising, Sport, and Physic...	98.82
Visual Effects, Movements, S...	98.86
Fictional Media Characters	98.88
Body Parts	98.88
Materials and Surfaces	98.89
Performers and Entertainers	98.98
Sounds and Sound Effects	99.01
Touch and Bodily Sensation	99.13
Passage and Repetition of Ti...	99.13
Media Techniques and Effects	99.18
Vantage Point and Visual Focus	99.18
Accessories	99.21
Smell	99.24
Historical, Mythical, and Relig...	99.30
Digital Platforms and Applicat...	99.34

Animal and Creature Descript...	99.64
Creators, Writers, and Direct...	99.65
Institutional, Commercial, an...	99.73
Text and Visual Language	99.75

★ See “InterCoder Question & Discussion” document for final meeting discussion guidance

- Largely, I let the intercoders lead the direction of the discussion (realigning or moving on to another question using the guidance document) to give them agency and authority over their own opinion and voice as a researcher.
- I didn’t “correct” or act as an answer book (of which there is none in qualitative research, I believe), but was more interested in the back-and-forth and coming to a joint agreement between us.
 - In qualitative research, getting other coders’ interpretation and reading on the data is the important part of this validation stage/process. It is important that they feel able to tell me where they disagree with me and why.

[Coder A]: Dec4th2025 meeting

→ Human-made and societal places	agrmt % 90.02
→ Media genres, eras, and formats	agrmt % 90.82
→ Musical and sonic qualities	agrmt % 91.64
→ Scene qualities and atmosphere	agrmt % 94.08
→ Emotions and affective states	agrmt % 94.88
→ Genre, cultural, and aesthetic labels	agrmt % 94.89

Meeting quick notes:

- Media genre needs its own category to separate out from basic media type descriptors
- Sonic qualities could be added, separate from music descriptors?
- Perhaps use word “biome” in describing some landforms and natural settings (ecology student)
- Traits of other people sometimes coded to emotions and affective states —discrimination between traits and basic character descriptors not immediately parseable
- Is “smoky” a sensory smell or scene quality?
- Jazz bar and French cafe very common
- Put “gardens” in plants, but unsure on reflection

- “Game console” in objects or a media category?
- Where to put “cooking”? What kind of action?
- Outfit items should have it’s own category separate from descriptors (e.g. funky sequin skirt?)
- “Crowds” often put in scene qualities (*I think better put in social collectives in character category*)
- Notes that historical periods could be denoted by the scene or object descriptors
- Personal significance stood out, particularly paired with mentions of people —descriptions that were sentimental were most memorable
- Suggestion that emotional connection to music, however it comes up, results in those “deep” descriptions and sometimes more creative imaginings?

[Coder B]: Dec1st2025 meeting

→ Human-made and societal places	agrmt % 91.79
→ Media genres, eras, and formats	agrmt % 92.12
→ Musical and sonic qualities	agrmt % 92.64
→ Emotions and affective states	agrmt % 94.34

Meeting quick notes:

- “Beach” was coded to settings category
- Time-period vs genre categorisation (e.g. 00s) sometimes ambiguous
- Media genres needs its own category separate from formats and descriptors
- Suggests going back over companies —when to discriminate between the objects & things companies vs media companies?
- Scene qualities sometimes hard to distinguish between e.g. musical qualities and felt emotions
- Social presence, particularly *alone*, needs “explicit mention” added to the definition —as it stands currently, any description without mentioning another character could all go in *alone*.
- Should “sun” be coded to nature/weather, or light and illumination?
- Can time periods and events be split up (question of a potential need for shorter periods?)
- Observations that driving (action) often came with cars (transport object) and places, felt emotions came with time/events, family and friends came with personal significance, events often came with evaluations/preferences
- Noted frustration at some “lazy responses” purely using single words —makes it hard to code!

[Coder C]: Dec1st2025 meeting

→ Human-made and societal places	agrmt % 91.72
→ Musical and sonic qualities	agrmt % 92.67
→ Media genres, eras, and formats	agrmt % 93.06

Meeting quick notes:

- “Beach” to go in societal places (setting) or water features? Coded to settings
- Unsure of how to use the “transforming” category? Needs renaming, definition clarification, and other examples
- Some media tech and vantage point coding was ambiguous
- Clarification on traits relating to a character vs emotion felt by listener
- Media genres need their own category rather than mass grouping with formats and descriptors
- Scene qualities not immediately understood/used, could do with definition clarification
- Put “aliens” in creatures
- Where do phones go? Technology in media, or objects & things?
- Smoky jazz club was the most common pairing of coding (fed up with seeing it haha)
- Came across ID 824 —commented on worrying contents of the opinionated commentary/rants
(^ removing this participant, see notes in Stage 2//Notes for self)

[Coder D&E]: Dec3rd2025 meeting

→ Human-made and societal places	agrmt % 91.97
→ Musical and sonic qualities	agrmt % 92.22
→ Media genres, eras, and formats	agrmt % 93.75

Meeting quick notes:

- Emotions and emotional tone in different categories are too close in wording to immediately understand their separation in the codebook —change wording and clarify definitions
- Where should “sun” go? Nature/sky/weather or light and illumination?
- “Bright” was often ambiguous —light, colour, music descriptor, scene quality, etc.?
- Reflection on *events*, needs theatre and concert shows in here (not sure if all were caught)
- Where does “fire” go? Hard to categorise!
- Where does “smoke” go? Particularly in the very common “smokey jazz club”...
- Outfit descriptors needs to be separated from outfit items
- Historical events weren’t super easy to categorise (e.g. from scene qualities or general descriptors)
- Music use and function needs clarification as to what can and should go in here
- Stand-out description particularly involved LOSS —very personal and often upsetting to read
- The “approach and connection” to music and/or the imaginings/memories that come up are hard to separate from each other, seeming innately tied to each other —how can you tell what has the main pulling force?

See Stage 2 Codebook for the refined and iterated codebook following consensus from coder meetings.

Stage 3

Switch-over to *MAXQDA* from *NVivo* occurred here.

— *NVivo* was unable to handle the full 100% of the dataset coupled with exponentially increasingly coded sections causing frequent crashes and many lost “unresponsive” hours. Weighing this up combined with the difficulty of using this application to go through the full 100% of the dataset with its clunkiness in un-/re-coding specific sections, the time spent would already be too much.

— Changed to *MAXQDA*, loading in the full 100% of the dataset, and started on the fourth and final round of coding with a clean slate, seeing how easy it was to apply the newly refined codebook.

- NB: Found many other words/terms/phrases/names/songs/media/etc. initially missed in *NVivo* coding —*MAXQDA* very helpful!
- Shifting around sections and searching for specific words is far smoother and more intuitive here.
- Quantisation of coded categories is also easily possible here! Excellent.

See Stage 3 Codebook for the final codebook with definitions and examples.

Final revised decision on the themes and top-level categories:

- THEME 1: Narrational
 - Settings
 - Characters
 - Actions
 - Objects & Things
- THEME 2: Referential
 - Music & Sounds
 - Media, Art, & Technology
 - Chronology & Events
- THEME 1: Experiential
 - Personal significance & Subjective experiences

- Symbolic & Sensory representations

Full expanded subcodes from MAXQDA output:

Note: square brackets [] = uncodable parent category. That is, no data was directly coded into these categories, but they group and store subcodes (child codes) within them. Bolded and underlined = theme, bolded only = top-level category

1 NARRATIONAL

1.1 [Settings]

1.1.1 [Natural World]

1.1.1.1 Creatures

1.1.1.2 Terrains

1.1.1.3 Vegetation

1.1.1.4 Sky and Space

1.1.1.5 Water Features

1.1.1.6 Weather

1.1.2 Fictional and Spiritual Settings

1.1.3 Societal Places

1.1.4 Named Regional Places

1.1.5 Scene Qualities

1.1.6 Spatial Orientation

1.2 [Characters]

1.2.1 [Character Descriptors]

1.2.1.1 [Outfit Details]

1.2.1.1.1 Accessories

1.2.1.1.2 Hair

1.2.1.1.3 Outfit Descriptors

1.2.1.2 Identity

1.2.1.3 Professions and Pursuits

1.2.1.3.1 Music-related Professions and Pursuits

1.2.1.4 Relations

1.2.1.5 Archetypes

1.2.1.6 Social Collectives

- 1.2.1.7 Traits
- 1.2.2 [Named Figures]
 - 1.2.2.1 Creators
 - 1.2.2.2 Fictional Characters
 - 1.2.2.3 Historical and Mythical Figures
 - 1.2.2.4 Performers and Entertainers
- 1.2.3 [Social Presence]
 - 1.2.3.1 Solitude
 - 1.2.3.2 Dyads
 - 1.2.3.3 Groups
- 1.2.4 Body Parts
- 1.3 [Objects & Things]**
 - 1.3.1 Consumables
 - 1.3.2 Everyday Objects
 - 1.3.3 Transport
 - 1.3.4 Commerce and Organisations
 - 1.3.5 Materials and Surfaces
 - 1.3.6 Object Qualities
- 1.4 [Actions]**
 - 1.4.1 [Agentic Actions]
 - 1.4.1.1 Directed Movement
 - 1.4.1.2 Daily life
 - 1.4.1.3 Music-linked Movement
 - 1.4.1.4 Sports
 - 1.4.1.5 Creating and Performing
 - 1.4.1.6 Relational and Social
 - 1.4.1.7 Consuming
 - 1.4.1.8 Conflict and Wrongdoing
 - 1.4.2 [Processes and States]
 - 1.4.2.1 Perceptual acts
 - 1.4.2.2 Non-directional Motions
 - 1.4.2.3 Rest and Leisure
 - 1.4.2.4 Transforming and Learning

1.4.2.5 Waiting and Anticipating

1.4.3 [Action Modifiers]

1.4.3.1 Speed

1.4.3.2 Characterisation

2 REFERENTIAL

2.1 [Music & Sounds]

2.1.1 Instruments, Ensembles, and Imitations

2.1.2 Music Use and Function

2.1.3 Sound Qualities

2.1.3.1 Music Genre, Cultural, and Stylistic Labels

2.1.3.2 Technical and Structural Music Elements

2.1.4 Playback and Listening Devices

2.1.5 Named Artists and Musicians

2.1.6 Named Songs and Lyrics

2.1.7 Sounds and Sound Effects

2.2 [Media, Art, & Technology]

2.2.1 Media Formats

2.2.2 Media Genres and Styles

2.2.3 Media Packaging Structures

2.2.4 Media Techniques and Effects

2.2.5 Music and Sound in Media

2.2.6 Media Companies and Devices

2.2.7 Digital Platforms and Applications

2.2.8 Named Media References

2.3 [Chronology & Events]

2.3.1 Events and Occasions

2.3.2 Historical Events and Periods

2.3.3 Narrative Progression

2.3.4 Passage and Repetition of Time

2.3.5 Seasons and Time

3 EXPERIENTIAL

3.1 [Symbolic & Sensory Representations]

3.1.1 [Sensory Details]

3.1.1.1 [Visual Details]

3.1.1.1.1 Colour

3.1.1.1.2 Illumination

3.1.1.1.3 Text

3.1.1.1.4 Vantage Point

3.1.1.1.5 Oddities, Effects, Shapes, Patterns

3.1.1.2 Smell

3.1.1.3 Bodily Sensation

3.1.2 Conceptual and Metaphorical References

3.2 [Subjective & Personal Experience]

3.2.1 Emotions and Affective States

3.2.2 Opinions and Preferences

3.2.3 Personal Significance

3.2.4 Personal Time-linked Connections